

Barriers to Listening

Listening is not easy, and many obstacles stand in the way of effective listening, both within and outside the workplace. These barriers may be categorised as follows.

1. Physiological Barriers: - some people may have genuine hearing problems or deficiencies that prevent them from listening correctly. It can be treated. Some people may have difficulties processing or retaining information in their memory, such as a lack of concentration/interest.

2. Physical Barriers: - These refer to environmental distractions, such as the sound of an air conditioner, cigarette smoke, or an overheated room. It can interfere with the Listening process. They could also be in the form of information overload; for example, if you are in a meeting with your manager, and the phone rings, your mobile beeps simultaneously to let you know you have the message. It is tough to listen carefully to what is being said and arrive late for a speech, presentation or lecture. Therefore, listeners are unavailable. Speakers or listeners distracted by disturbances will also enter the physical barrier category.

3. Attitudinal Barriers: - preoccupation with personal or work-related problems can make it difficult to focus entirely on what the speaker is saying, even if what is being said is very important. Another common attitudinal barrier is egocentrism, or the belief that the person is more knowledgeable than the speaker or that there is nothing new to learn from the speaker's ideas. People with this kind of close-minded attitude are destitute listeners.

4. Wrong Assumptions: - Communication success depends on both the sender and receiver. It is wrong to assume that communication is the sole responsibility of the sender or the speaker and that listeners have no role to play. Such an assumption can be a significant barrier to listening. For example, a brilliant speech or presentation, however well delivered, is wasted if the receiver is not listening at the other end. Listeners have as much responsibility as speakers to make the communication successful. The process should be successful by paying attention, seeking clarifications, and giving feedback. Another example is assuming that the speaker will provide some unimportant information. Or Pre-judgments about the speaker.

5. Cultural Barriers: - Accents can be barriers to listening since they interfere with the ability to understand the meaning of words that are pronounced differently. The problem of different accents arises between cultures and within a culture. For example, accents may differ even between regions and states in a country like India, which has enormous cultural diversity.

6. Gender Barriers: - communication research has shown that gender can hinder listening. Studies have revealed that men and women listen differently and for different purposes. Women are more likely to listen for the emotion behind a speaker's words, while men listen more for the facts and the content.

7. Lack of Training: - Listening is not an inborn skill. People are not born good listeners. It is developed through practice and training. Lack of training in listening skills is an important barrier. In lack of training, people avoid listening to difficult, tedious, or complex information and selectively listen only to what is considered interesting.

8. Bad Listening Habits: - Most people are very average listeners who have developed poor listening habits that are hard to say and that act as barriers to listening. For example, some people habitually “fake” attention or try to look like listeners to impress the speaker and assure him that they are paying attention. Others may tend to listen to every fact and, as a result, miss out on the main point. For example, Judging the speaker by their mannerisms, voice, appearance, accent, etc.

How To Listen Effectively?

1. Stop Talking – Be Silent
2. Show Interest
3. Empathise
4. Ask Questions
5. Maintain Eye Contact
6. Take notes
7. Listen Creatively
8. Put Your Entirety
9. Send feedback
10. Avoid or eliminate distraction
11. To develop interest and familiarity, gather information about the topic.

Benefits of Effective Listening

The skill of effective listening benefits personal growth and development in the following ways:

- **Enhances productivity:** When we develop the habit of listening attentively and improving our concentration, we can do our work more efficiently. Listening skills make one a good resource for various work as concentration levels improve, too.
- **Improves relations:** Relationships are damaged by misunderstandings that can lead to unsatisfactory business transactions and hurt feelings in personal relationships. Excellent listening

practices tell others they are important and unique and that what they say is valued. That is very attractive and contributes to strong relationships

- **Avoids conflicts:** Listening attentively improves a person's understanding level. They will listen more and speak less, automatically reducing relationship conflicts. When people understand better, they don't argue, so conflict rarely occurs.

- **Improves understanding (Reduces Misunderstanding):** Regardless of the clarity of written or spoken messages, the effective listener can prevent misunderstandings and salvage what otherwise might be a miscommunication by practising active listening skills

- **Improves negotiation skills (Effective Communication):** Clear and concise transmission of information is an important component of effective human interaction. Though the onus is often placed on presenting clear and concise written or spoken directions, the listener is also responsible for hearing and understanding messages.

- **Adds to your Image and Personality (Personal Growth):** A person learns and grows by listening and understanding other viewpoints, differing ideas, and exploring conflicting views. Learning the skill of active and effective listening adds a tool to the personal development portfolio and equips you to continue growing with tools for exploring new ideas.

Ways to improve Listening skill

Hearing and Listening are two different activities. Hearing is passive, whereas Listening is active. Listening is a psychological process. It can, therefore, be improved by regular practice. Listening is a beneficial skill. Active listening is an extension of the Golden Rule. Here are some of the tips which can help the person to improve his Listening skill:

1. Face the speaker. Sit up straight or lean forward slightly to show your attentiveness through body language.
2. Maintain eye contact to the degree that you all remain comfortable.
3. Minimise external distractions. Turn off the TV. Put down your book or magazine, and ask the speaker and other listeners to do the same.
4. Respond appropriately to show that you understand. Murmur ("uh-huh" and "um-hmm") and nod. Raise your eyebrows. Say words such as "Really" and "Interesting," as well as more direct prompts: "What did you do then?" and "What did she say?"
5. Focus solely on what the speaker is saying. Try not to think about what you are going to say next. The conversation will follow a logical flow after the speaker makes her point.

6. Minimise internal distractions. If your thoughts keep hanging in, let them go and continuously re-focus your attention on the speaker as you would during meditation.
7. Keep an open mind. Wait until the speaker is finished before deciding that you disagree. Try not to make assumptions about what the speaker is thinking.
8. Avoid letting the speaker know how you handled a similar situation. Unless they specifically ask for advice, assume they just need to talk it out.
9. Even if the speaker is launching a complaint against you, wait until they finish to defend yourself. The speaker will feel as though their point has been made. They won't feel the need to repeat it, and you'll know the whole argument before you respond. Research shows that, on average, we can hear four times faster than we can talk, so we can sort ideas as they come in...and be ready for more.
10. Engage yourself. Ask questions for clarification, but wait again until the speaker has finished. That way, you won't interrupt their train of thought. After you ask questions, paraphrase their point to ensure you didn't misunderstand. Start with: "So you're saying..."